

TX.3 Inspection Sequence

Inside a city: the inspection ladder and who runs it. Outside one: the five separate inspectors that exist, the gaps where nobody inspects at all, and a log for both.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Texas has no single permit counter: each city administers its own permits and code editions, county programs vary, and several state agencies each own one piece of the picture. Confirm every item with the office that will actually issue it before you rely on it. On Track A your permit card lists the inspections your job requires — it governs. On Track B, this document is the closest thing to a permit card you will get.

TRACK A — THE MUNICIPAL LADDER

No Texas statute enumerates residential inspections; each city's adopted IRC and local amendments do. The ladder below is the **typical** shape — verify names and count against your own city's published list. Two verified anchors: **San Antonio** publishes a Residential Inspection Guide with inspections at each covered stage, and requires final inspections in **Building, Electrical, Mechanical, Gas, Plumbing, and a Tree Inspection** before the certificate of occupancy and utility transfer. **Fort Worth's** General Inspections List has the foundation approved with steel in place before concrete, framing called only after the trade rough-ins, and a final inspection that "finals out" all permits and supports the CO.

Typical municipal ladder — verify locally; names and count vary

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified
1. T-pole / temporary power	Temporary construction service inspected and released to the utility.
2. Plumbing rough (underground)	Under-slab plumbing inspected before the slab is poured.
3. Foundation / pre-pour	Forms, steel, and embedments in place — approved before any concrete is placed (Fort Worth words it exactly that way).
4. Framing + trade rough-ins	Framing with electrical, plumbing, and mechanical rough-ins complete — called only after the trades are in. Coastal: windstorm nailing/connector inspections fall here too (see Track B, windstorm).
5. Insulation / energy	Insulation and air-sealing verified against the city's energy code before cover.
6. Wallboard	Some cities inspect drywall fastening before tape and float.
7. Gas test	Pressure test witnessed before the meter is set.

Typical municipal ladder — verify locally; names and count vary

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified
8. Sewer / water yard lines	Yard utilities inspected before burial.
9. Trade finals	Electrical, plumbing, mechanical (and gas) each final out.
10. Building final → CO	The building final closes the permit; the certificate of occupancy issues (San Antonio requires the CO application after all finals; Fort Worth issues the CO at final-out).

San Antonio Residential Inspection Guide, docsonline.sanantonio.gov; Fort Worth General Inspections List, fortworthtexas.gov — both read August 2026. The ladder itself is a typical composite, not any one city's list: your permit card governs.

TRACK A — INSPECTION LOG**Track A inspection log**

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
T-pole / temp power					
Plumbing rough (u/g)					
Foundation / pre-pour					
Framing + rough-ins					
Insulation / energy					
Wallboard					
Gas test					
Yard lines					
Final — electrical					
Final — plumbing					
Final — mechanical					
Final — building / CO					

Track A inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes

TRACK B — THERE IS NO LADDER; THERE ARE FIVE SEPARATE INSPECTORS

In the unincorporated county nobody owns your job the way a city inspections department does. Each inspection below exists on its own legal track, with its own inspector, and **you** are the only person who will ever sequence them. Between them are gaps — work that is regulated but never inspected — covered honestly below, because pretending an inspection exists is how corners get built wrong.

The five inspectors that exist on Track B

Who	What actually happens	Authority
Septic (OSSF)	The authorized agent (usually the county) inspects the installation under 30 TAC Ch. 285 before the system is covered or used . Constructing without the permit and approved plan is unlawful.	H&S Code §§ 366.004, 366.051; 30 TAC Ch. 285
Windstorm (coastal only)	After the WPI-1 notice, TDI or your engineer inspects at each construction phase — contact TDI for each phase when TDI is the inspector. WPI-8/WPI-8-E certificate at the end. A phase covered up uninspected cannot be certified.	Ins. Code § 2210.2515; tdi.texas.gov/wind
Energy code	Your chosen § 388.004 route IS the inspection: an accredited program (e.g., an ERI/ENERGY STAR rating), a private code-certified inspector, or the ESL builder self-certification form. Keep the documentation three years; give the owner a copy.	H&S Code § 388.004
Subchapter F counties only	Three private inspections YOU arrange and pay for: foundation before concrete, framing/mechanical before drywall, and final — by one of the six listed inspector types — with county notice forms where required. El Paso County runs a worked example of this program.	Loc. Gov't Code § 233.154; epcounty.com
Utility meter release	The de facto final. Electric cooperatives require a passing meter-loop inspection before energizing new construction — Bluebonnet Electric's tariff requires it "for all new and existing locations," with a \$125 re-inspection fee on failure. Requirements differ by utility; some require a licensed electrician's certification or a third-party inspection. Call your provider's new-construction desk before you wire.	Bluebonnet tariff § III (verified example)

The honest gap — licensing applies; routine inspection does not exist

Electrical: nobody inspects by default. The licensing law still applies and the work must meet the 2023 NEC even in unincorporated areas (Occ. Code § 1305.201(e)) — but no state agency performs residential electrical inspections there. TDLR licenses people, not houses. The practical inspectors are the utility at meter release, your lender's draw inspector, and your insurer. The same logic covers plumbing and HVAC: code duties without a code official.

What to do about it: hire a private code-certified inspector for the stages a city would have inspected — pre-pour, rough-in, pre-drywall, final. It is the cheapest insurance on the job, and on the energy chapter it doubles as your § 388.004(2) compliance route.

Lender and insurer inspections — construction-loan draw inspections and the insurer's replacement-cost or four-point-style reviews — are, in practice, the only whole-house quality gates on this track. That is practical reality, not law; treat their checklists as a floor, not a code.

There is no CO out here — these are the occupancy gates

No statute creates a certificate of occupancy in unincorporated Texas. What functions instead: the **OSSF approval** (you cannot lawfully use the septic system without the permit — H&S Code § 366.051), the **meter release** (no power without it), and — coastal — the **windstorm certificate**, without which TWIA coverage is not available. Clear all three and you are as "final" as Track B gets.

TRACK B — INSPECTION LOG

Track B inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
OSSF — site evaluation					
OSSF — pre-cover / final					
Windstorm — foundation phase					
Windstorm — framing phase					
Windstorm — final / WPI-8					
Energy — route inspection / cert					
Subch. F — foundation pre-pour					

Track B inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Subch. F — frame pre-drywall					
Subch. F — final					
Private inspector — rough-in					
Private inspector — final					
Meter-loop / utility release					

OSSF operation approved: _____ Meter released: _____ WPI-8 issued (coastal): _____

Sources (verified August 2026). *Municipal ladders: San Antonio Residential Inspection Guide* (docsonline.sanantonio.gov) — six required finals before the CO; *Fort Worth General Inspections List* (fortworthtexas.gov) — steel before concrete, framing after rough-ins, final-out. OSSF inspection before cover/use and the unlawfulness of unpermitted construction — Health & Safety Code §§ 366.004, 366.051; 30 TAC Ch. 285. Unincorporated electrical work must meet the state electrical code (2023 NEC) with no routine state inspection — Occ. Code § 1305.201(e); 16 TAC § 73.100. Windstorm phase inspections and certificates — Insurance Code § 2210.2515; tdi.texas.gov/wind. Energy compliance routes and the three-year documentation duty — Health & Safety Code § 388.004. Subchapter F private inspections and notices — Local Gov't Code § 233.154 (El Paso County program, epcounty.com). Meter-loop inspection — Bluebonnet Electric Cooperative tariff, Section III: one verified example; your utility's requirements govern.